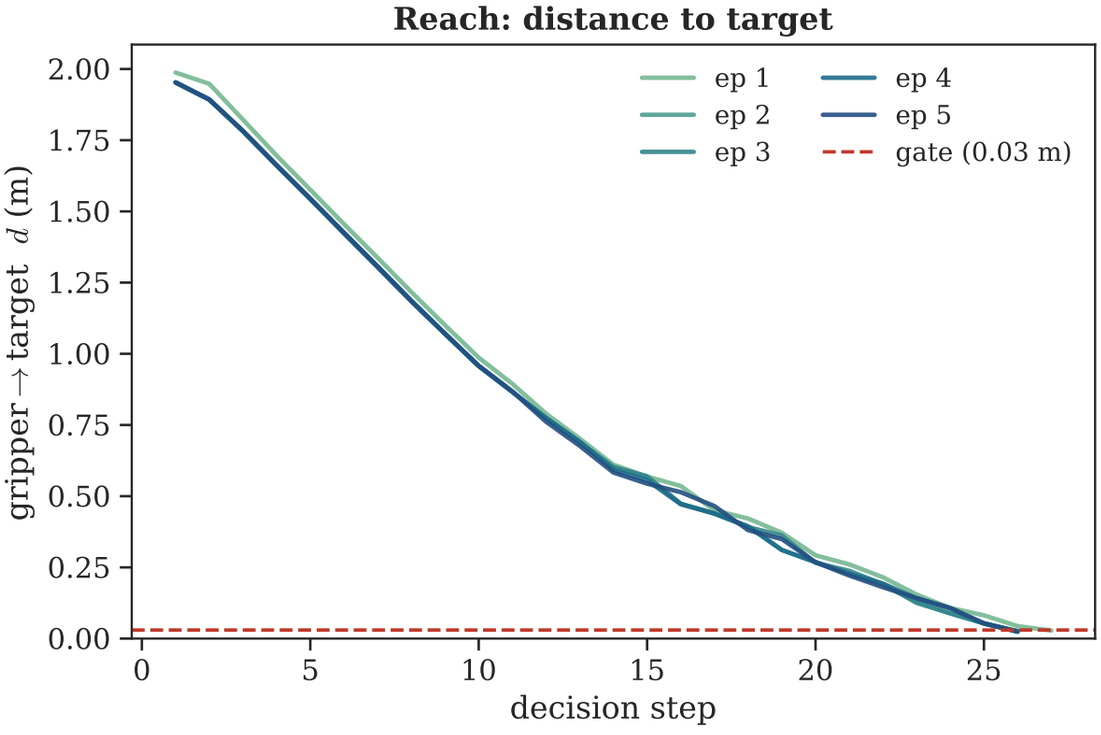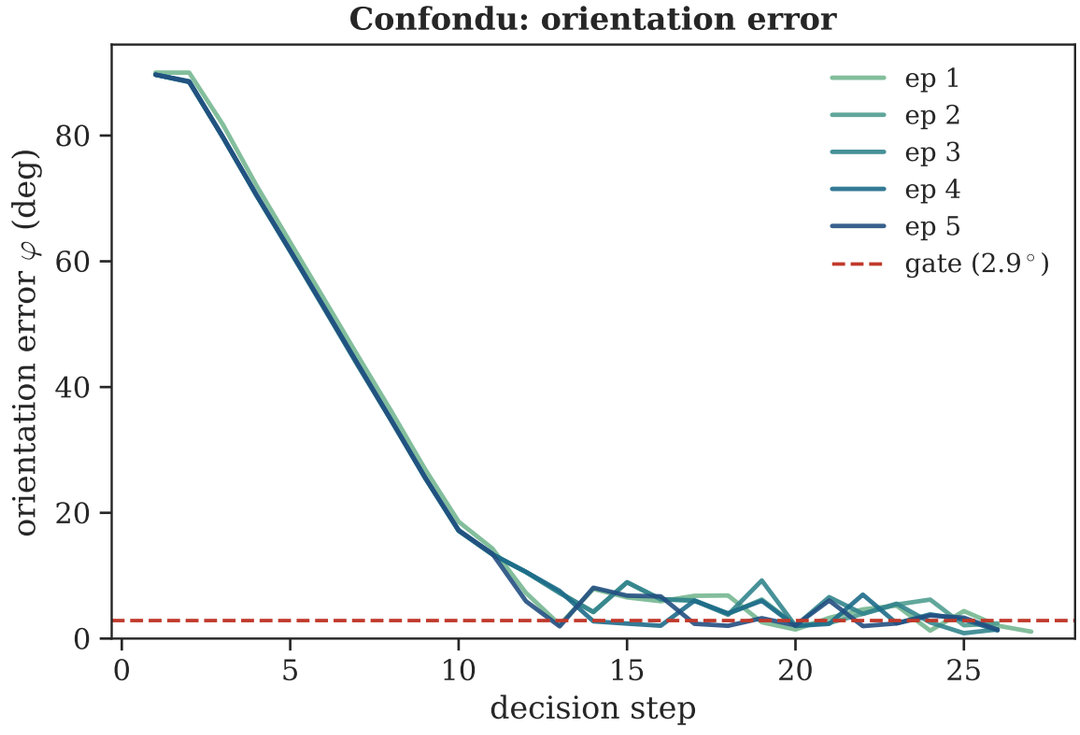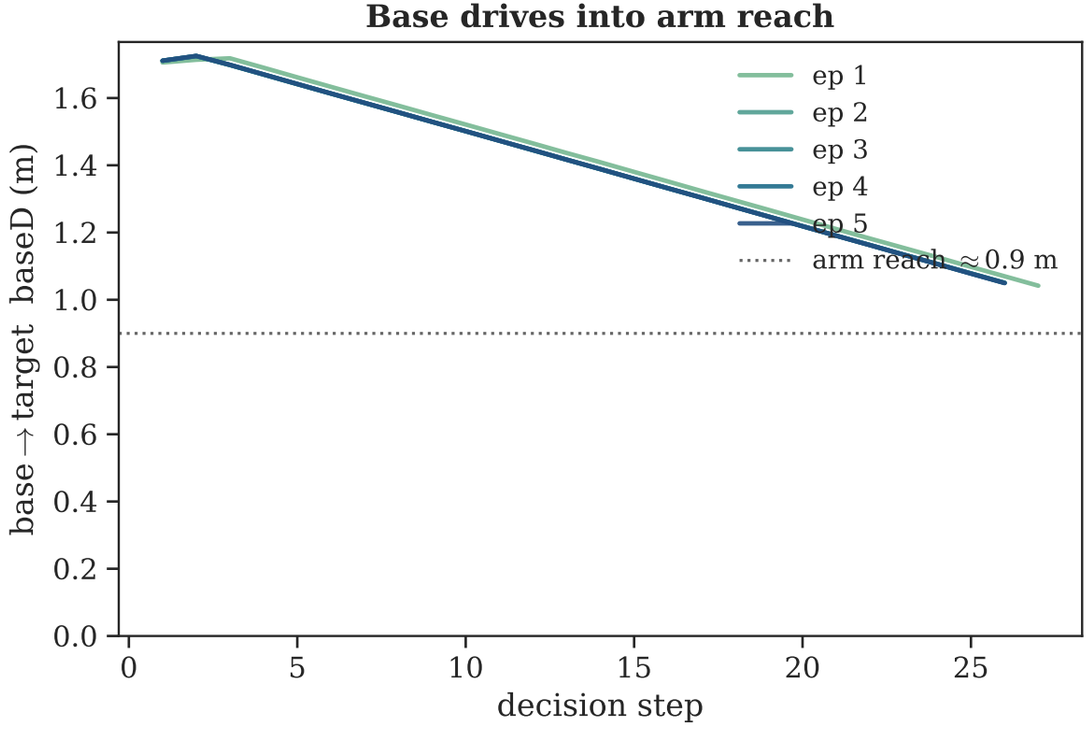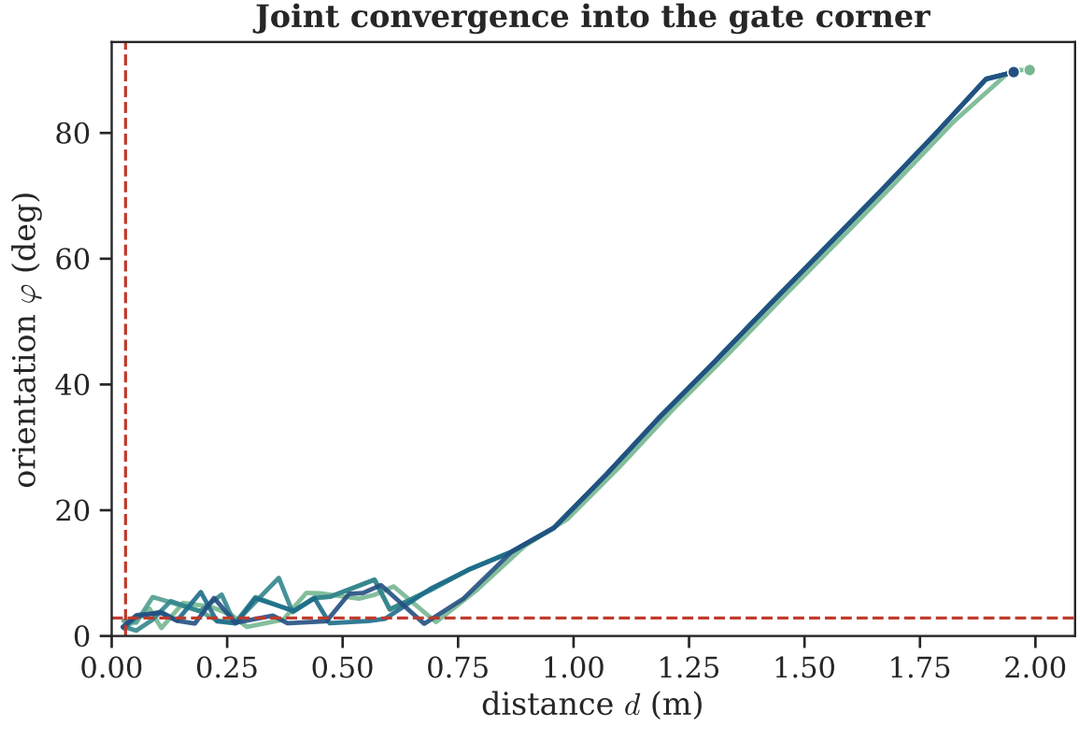s9_np — fixed-target deterministic evaluation